Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ 10 7 3 ♥ K J 5 4 ♦ K 7 ♣ A Q 10 6	
♠ K J 9 2 ♥ 7 ♦ 10 6 5 3 2 ♣ 8 5 3		♠ Q 6 5 4 ♥ 9 6 ♦ A Q J 9 ♣ K 7 2
	♠ A 8 ♥ A Q 10 8 3 2 ♦ 8 4 ♣ J 9 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	Pass	1♥
Pass	2♥	Pass	4♥
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♠2

Don't even think of jumping to 2♥. That would show 17+ points. Instead you just bid 1♥, knowing partner is forced to bid again.

Partner does bid again, saying 2♥.

Partner's rebid promises a minimum opening bid (13-15) and four ♥s. That makes your total about 28 points and ten ♥s. So you bid game.

South plays 4♥. West leads the ♠2, East playing the ♠Q.

South plays 4♥. West leads the ♠2, East playing the ♠Q.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 1 : Total = 4

If the ♣ finesse works you have no ♣ loser, and as a bonus you will be able to discard one of your other losers. Even if the finesse fails you still have an extra winner for the discard.

Is there a danger here? Yes. Suppose you win the first trick, pull trumps, then finesse the ♣. East might win and play a ♠ back to West's hand. And West might then lead a ♦ through dummy's ♦K.

West is the Danger Hand. You want to keep him off the lead. His only possible entry is the ♠ suit, so all you have to do is hold up on the first trick. Win the second ♠, pull trumps as before, and finesse the ♣. East wins but cannot get to his partner's hand for the killing ♦ lead. You will discard one of your ♦ losers on dummy's fourth ♣.

You usually think of a hold-up play in a Notrump contract, trying to exhaust one defender of his partner's suit.

For this deal the hold-up serves a different purpose. It keeps one defender from ever gaining the lead.

You had to lose one ♠ in any case, so you just choose to lose it to the defender who cannot hurt you.

Notice that the Danger Hand **WAS** on lead at one point - the opening lead. If West had been clairvoyant enough to lead a ♦ the contract could have been beaten. Opening leads are important to the defense.

Board 2
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ 7 2 ♥ K Q 8 7 6 3 ♦ K 9 4 ♣ 8 5	
♠ Q J 10 8 4 ♥ 4 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ K 6 4 3	N W E S	♠ 9 6 5 3 ♥ 10 9 5 2 ♦ A 8 5 ♣ 10 9
	♠ A K ♥ A J ♦ Q J 10 2 ♣ A Q J 7 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♥	Pass	2NT
Pass	3♦	Pass	6NT
All Pass			

6NT by South
Lead: ♠Q

You were probably stunned when you picked up this hand and even more stunned when partner bid.

Your biggest problem is that partner has opened with a weak bid and won't credit you with such a huge hand. So you must make sure you don't make a bid he might pass until you're ready.

For example, suppose you made a jump shift to 4♣. Would partner know what that meant? Do you know what it meant?

The best(?) bid at this point is probably 2NT. Everybody knows what that means. Partner is forced to reply, and will either rebid his suit with a minimum hand or show a "feature" if his hand is better than minimum.

Partner replies 3♦.

Trust your partner. He has shown a better-than-minimum Weak-2 bid, probably 9-11 points, and a high card in ♦s, either the ♦A or ♦K.

With your hand you don't need anything else to make a slam. You have to decide between 6♥ and 6NT. Based on your reluctance to have an opening ♣ lead go through your ♣ A Q you choose 6NT.

South plays 6NT. West leads the ♠Q.

South plays 6NT. West leads the ♠Q.

Winners: ♠ 2 : ♥ 6? : ♦ 0 : ♣ 1 : Total = 9

The winner list isn't as bad as it looks, once you drive out the ♦A you'll have your three extra winners in ♦s.

In fact, your only real problem is making sure you get all 6 ♥ winners. If the ♥s split 3-2 it's easy, but if they are 4-1 you cannot afford to overtake the ♥J at the second trick. Fortunately dummy has both the ♦K and the ♦9.

Win the ♠A. Play ♥A and ♥J. West shows out on the second one. Lead your ♦2 to dummy's ♦9. Either you are in dummy now to run the ♥s, or East wins the trick with the ♦A. In this case you can win his return (don't finesse if he leads a ♣), and get to dummy with the ♦K to run the ♥s.

A 4-1 split isn't as likely as a 3-2 split.

But when you can

In this case dummy had a certain entry in the ♦ suit so you take advantage of that entry.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ 7 3
♥ 5 4 3 2
♦ Q 4
♣ A K 10 8 3

♠ Q 6
♥ A
♦ A K J 9 6 5
♣ 9 7 5 2

♠ K 10 9 8 5 2
♥ 9 7
♦ 10 2
♣ Q J 4

♠ A J 4
♥ K Q J 10 8 6
♦ 8 7 3
♣ 6

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
2♦	2♥	2♠	Pass
Pass	3♥		
All Pass			

3♥ by South
Lead: ♦A

With 11 points you would probably have bid 3♥, a limit raise, if East hadn't overcalled.

But you now doubt your ♦Q is worth 2 points so you just say 2♥.

Now West comes in with 2♠ and it is passed around to you.

With a known 9-card fit this hand is worth a 3♥ bid.

Everybody passes.

North would play 3♥.

South plays 3♥. West leads ♦A, ♦K, ♦J. East plays first the ♦10, then ♦2.

South plays 3♥. West leads ♦A, ♦K, ♦J. East plays first the ♦10, then ♦2.

Losers: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 3 : ♣ 0 : Total = 6

Although there are two ♠ losers in your hand, one can either be ruffed in dummy or discarded on a high ♣. So you really only have one loser too many.

You should realize that if you ruff this ♦ with one of dummy's teensy ♥s it will be over-ruffed. East did signal a doubleton. The loss of the teensy ♥ doesn't worry you, you have plenty of them. But the loss of the opportunity to dump a loser should worry you a lot.

So don't ruff at all. Discard a ♠. Now you can ruff your other ♠ loser in dummy.

Be ever watchful for situations where you may be over-ruffed.

Often, like in this deal, you can discard a loser instead.

Board 4
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 9 2 ♥ 8 5 ♦ K 6 5 2 ♣ A J 10 3 2	
♠ K J 7 3 ♥ Q 7 6 2 ♦ 10 9 3 ♣ 9 5	N W E S	♠ 10 8 6 5 ♥ K 9 4 3 ♦ 7 4 ♣ 8 7 4
	♠ A Q 4 ♥ A J 10 ♦ A Q J 8 ♣ K Q 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2♣
Pass	3♣	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♦[2]	Pass	5NT[3]
Pass	6♦[4]	Pass	6NT
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace
3. asks for kings
4. 1 king

6NT by South
Lead: ♦10

With 9 points you have enough strength to make a positive response. And with a good 5-card suit you respond 3♣.

Partner says 4NT.

Partner's 4NT bid is clearly Blackwood. With one Ace you answer 5♦.

Partner says 5NT.

Partner's 5NT bid guarantees that your side has all the Aces, and asks for your Kings. With one King you answer 6♦.

Partner says 6NT and you pass.

North would play 6NT.

South plays 6NT. West leads the ♦10.

South plays 6NT. West leads the ♦10.

Winner count: ♠ 1 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 4 : ♣ 5 : Total = 11

You need just one more winner. If the ♠K is with East then a simple finesse will provide it. This would not be a terrible plan - you can expect it to succeed 50% of the time. Of course that means you will go down the other 50% of the time.

The double finesse in ♥s is better. If East holds **EITHER** the ♥K **OR** the ♥Q you will succeed. This raises your chances to 75%.

So win the opening lead with dummy's ♦K. Play the ♥5, finessing your ♥10. West will probably win this with either ♥K or ♥Q. No matter. Win West's probable ♦ return and take 5 ♣ tricks, discarding your 2 ♠ losers. Lead dummy's ♥7 and finesse the ♥J. When this wins the rest of the tricks are yours.

Sometimes you will have two or three possible ways to try for a contract. You need to evaluate them as to which is the most likely to succeed. There are times when this can be very difficult to analyze, but fortunately some choices are pretty easy to make.

The choice between a single finesse and a double finesse is one that you will face many times. So remember that the double finesse works 75% of the time.

Board 5
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 8 3 ♥ 6 4 ♦ 10 6 ♣ K Q 10 8 7 3 2	
♠ J 9 5 2 ♥ K 8 7 3 ♦ A 7 5 2 ♣ 6	N W E S	♠ A Q 10 ♥ J 10 9 5 2 ♦ J 9 4 3 ♣ 5
	♠ K 7 6 4 ♥ A Q ♦ K Q 8 ♣ A J 9 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♣
Pass	5♣		
All Pass			

5♣ by South
Lead: ♦A

This is **NOT** a simple choice.

Partner may have a hand where 3NT is a laydown. Or he may have a hand where 3NT is a godown.

Science isn't going to help you so you guess that 5♣ probably has a good chance.

North would play 5♣.

South plays 5♣. West leads ♦A, then ♦2.

South plays 5♣. West leads ♦A, then ♦2.

Losers: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 0 : Total = 4

MAYBE East will have the ♠A and the ♥K. But maybe not. You do have an extra ♦ trick so you need to determine the best use you can make of that.

First pull trumps. It takes one round. Play your other ♦ winner and discard one of dummy's ♠s. This protects you from losing more than one ♠. Enter dummy with a trump and lead the last ♠. Assume East has the ♠A. If he goes up with it you will be able to dump dummy's ♥ loser on your ♠K. If he plays low you put on your ♠K and you no longer have a ♠ loser.

If it turns out West has the ♠A then your ♠ play didn't work. In that case you would enter dummy again and try the ♥ finesse. This plan is a winner if East holds **EITHER** the ♥K or the ♠A.

It's always nice to give yourself two chances.

With correct play you succeed when East holds the ♠A, but also if he holds the ♥K.

The key play was dumping the ♠ on your ♦K rather than a ♥.